





CINEMA

KEEPING US GUESSING

The new superhero film Minnal Murali *has added to* ***Tovino Thomas's*** *reputation as a performer who keeps experimenting*

Tovino Thomas is, to put it mildly, a good-looking man with considerable screen presence. But that in itself doesn't account for the important part he is playing in the Malayalam cinema renaissance. What is more notable is that Tovino's best work gets its tension from the contrast between his hunky charm, and a vulnerability—or even unlikability—in his characters.

Some fine films—two recent examples being *Kala* (2021), which he also co-produced, and *Kaanekkaane* (2021)—have used this dichotomy to terrific effect. In both, Tovino's personality and physical appearance help subvert a narrative, or keep us guessing. In *Kala*, the stylised early sequences, including a lovemaking scene, suggest that his feral character Shaji is the protagonist. But Shaji loses much of his self-assurance and we see him in a different light. In *Kaanekkaane*, as a man whose wife died in an accident, Tovino looks lost and distracted, then shows heartfelt emotion—but much suspense hinges on the possibility that the character is a philanderer who lied to his ex-father-in-law; so what else might he be capable of?

TOVINO THOMAS'S BEST WORK GETS ITS TENSION FROM THE CONTRAST BETWEEN HIS HUNKY CHARM AND HIS CHARACTERS' VULNERABILITY

"I have to be entertained by what I'm doing," Tovino tells us during a phone interview. "Money and fame should only be the byproducts of me pushing my limits." This is also why he tries to change his appearance from one role to the next, and enthusiastically tells us to watch the trailer of his upcoming film *Naaradan*: "I have a new look there."

Different sides of his persona are also on view in *Minnal Murali*, the acclaimed new superhero film where he plays Jaison, a small-town tailor transformed after a lightning strike. The story moves towards a climax where Tovino strikes a heroic pose in his custom-fitted costume, but long before that, we see a man-child who sulks and mumbles "I deserve a better life!" to himself. "I enjoyed playing the many shades of Jaison—from a self-